

THE TALE OF YOUR WEEK
ISSUE NO. 4

The river

*Being a true account of Wren's week, Oct 22–28, as it was kept
by the Book, in 7 chapters.*





THU



FRI



SAT



SUN



MON



TUE



WED

A development sample. Wren's October is simulated. The photographs are real and were taken across several years. Photo keeps and Pagewright sheets were added for this sample after the saved nightly braids.

I want this one right at the front.

On Saturday, you wrote:

"the river, going gold"

Then on Sunday, you wrote:

"Sat with Amanda while she waited for news by the river."

I'm opening here. The rest is waiting inside.

THE CHAPTERS

CHAPTER THE FIRST · THURSDAY 22

In which you bought flowers for no one in particular before breakfast

CHAPTER THE SECOND · FRIDAY 23

In which you learned the name of the bakery cat after work

CHAPTER THE THIRD · SATURDAY 24

In which you oiled the squeaky kitchen door late at night

CHAPTER THE FOURTH · SUNDAY 25

In which you wore odd socks all day at the library

CHAPTER THE FIFTH · MONDAY 26

In which you tried a new route to work on the way home

CHAPTER THE SIXTH · TUESDAY 27

In which a few small things were kept

THE CHAPTERS, CONTINUED

CHAPTER THE SEVENTH · WEDNESDAY 28

In which a few small things were kept · Wednesday

IN THE ROOM



SERENITY



WICKER



PENNY



PROFESSOR



CHAPTER THE FIRST

*In which you bought flowers for
no one in particular before
breakfast*

Once upon a Thursday, under a waxing gibbous moon and the sky was clear, this is what happened.

Bought flowers for no one in particular before breakfast. It was nearly dark by then. Five kinds of yellow on one street. That came back from fourteen days ago: It makes the street feel like a room.

You crossed the ballroom to a beat you could follow. Empty coats swept past.

In the borrowed castle, Penny named source, invitation, and living claim. Serenity put her hand over the third card. That one was hers.

Penny says Tuesdays don't get lost, they get borrowed. I'd like to know by who.

Meanwhile, in the Labyrinth...

IN THE LABYRINTH · THE EAST STACKS

The Wrong Castle



The East Stacks grow a tower overnight.

You can see it from the Great Hall windows when the morning mist comes off: a thick dark finger standing where the library's east wing used to end. The bottom of it is *library*. It's got the right stone, the right narrow windows, the right smell of old glue. About halfway up, it changes its mind. There's a stretch of grey fortress wall with a flag on it that's no flag the Academy owns. And at the very top, as if the tower couldn't stop itself, there's a nursery window with yellow curtains and a wooden star hanging in the glass.

Between them runs a stair, and the stair keeps asking for another floor.

I can hear it from here. It's a slow soft *tick*, like a clock being wound. Each time the stair asks, the tower takes a stone from somewhere else and says yes.

A drawbridge hangs down over the Quillquarium. The nibs underneath are in a state. They've never agreed so completely, all thousand of them, in one long furious scribble, and the noise of it comes up

through the floor like bees in a wall.

I've read about a tower like this one. It was in a book, and the book was careful, and the tower stayed in the book. It wasn't supposed to get out.

Penny's pinning up a notice on the foot of the stair. She does it with a drawing-pin and quite a lot of dignity:

THE EAST STACKS ARE SEVERAL PLACES. PLEASE USE ONE AT A TIME.

Permancer is tying ribbons to the banister, one at every third post, in a pattern he's clearly worked out on paper. Wicker is holding the source volume, the old black copy of *Dracula*, open at the page, closed over his finger. He holds it like a man who's been handed a baby by an enemy. Serenity is studying her map.

It's been thirteen days since the East Stacks. She's gone back to her work. She's gone back to toast. She's lost no weight in the face and gained no softness, and on her neck, above the collar, there's a thin line that isn't quite scar and isn't quite not. She looks up from her map, and across the hall at the tower, and the corner of her mouth goes in.

"I'm coming," she says.

"I was about to ask," says Permancer.

"You're very slow."

"I'm very thorough."

"That's what I said."

She folds the map into her repaired case. It's the mended one, with the small crooked clasp. I watch the clasp click shut under her thumb, a clean small *snick*, and I watch Wicker, across the hall, watch it happen. He watches it the way you'd watch a bridge you've built take weight for the first time.

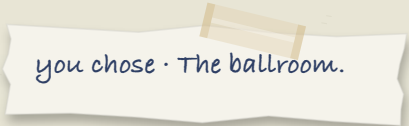
She catches him looking.

She doesn't smile. She doesn't scowl. She gives him a small, level nod, just a fraction of an inch, the kind you give to a stranger who's held a door. Then she goes ahead.

Permancer counts us at the doorway. He counts twice, now. He's started to count a third time, and he stops himself, and just holds the bookmark a moment longer than he needs to, and nobody says anything.

Inside, the stair turns into a corridor. It's a long one, lamplit, with a floor of old boards and, beyond a bend, three ways through.

I tie my ribbon to the doorframe behind us. It's the only thing I can do. It's the end I've got, and I leave it fluttering there like a flag on a very small ship, so that, whatever else happens, we'll be able to find the way out.



you chose · The ballroom.

The Wrong Castle

Dracula's waiting in the central hall.

It's a great high round room, built out of several different castles, and none of them has agreed to hold it up. The ceiling's from one place. The floor's from another. A fireplace in the north wall is blowing snow into the room, sideways, in long clean ribbons, and it's settling on the Count's coat. Above him, the stolen nursery window has swung in on its own wall, and is trying very hard to find morning.

"This is not my castle," he says.

He sounds, for the first time, uncertain. He sounds like a man standing in somebody else's kitchen.

"No," says Serenity. "These are everybody else's rooms."

She's got her map in both hands, and her chin up.

A door opens in the east wall, and through it there's a small boat in a great storm, the whole sea heaving past the frame. Permancer throws himself at the handle and drags it shut, and a quart of seawater goes through the gap and soaks him to the knees.

"You have damaged my source," says Dracula.

There's no heat in it. It's an accusation said very quietly, with a certain regret, by a man who's found his house wrecked and isn't sure whose fault it is.

Permancer keeps both hands on the handle. He's wet and he's tired and for once he's not lecturing.

"We did," he says.

It's a big thing, to say. I feel it go through the room. Nobody's expecting it, least of all the Count.

Wicker's holding the source volume open. He's standing very still, his shoulders drawn in, looking down at the page. His own sentence is there, in his own hand. *For one sentence, let him choose the verb.* And under it, in a second hand, small and neat, one word:

FOLLOW.

"I thought—" Wicker begins.

Serenity waits. She doesn't help him. She just waits.

He looks at the map case, with its crooked clasp. At the bandage above it, half hidden by her collar. He looks, I think, at everything he's ever made go wrong.

"I wanted to see what would happen."

"You have," says Serenity.

It's not cruel. It's perfectly level. He takes it. He lowers his eyes to the page and, for the first time since the Jump, doesn't look away.

Then the wall splits.

It happens quietly. There's a long thin crack, as if a very big breath has been let out behind the plaster, and where the stone parts there's something white. It's a fold of paper. A single sheet, thin as a held breath, running up the wall like ivy.

I know that paper.

I'd know it in the dark. I'd know it from across the Labyrinth. It's the same stuff I'm made of: the same flax, the same lime, the same long slow soak in a vat. It's *paper*. It's a page. And there's a gap in the page, a narrow clean tear like the one in the corner of a bookplate, and cold air's coming through it, and through the cold I can *hear* something. It's very far off. It sounds like a cover being opened.

Serenity touches the fold with one finger. Her map pulls toward the gap in her hands, the whole sheet stretching toward it like a plant.

“His way back,” she says.

Permancer brings the bookmark near. Its ribbons lift, one by one, and reach across the hall toward the source volume in Wicker's hands, toward the tear in the wall, and, slowly, almost reluctantly, toward Serenity.

Penny's already got three cards out. She sets one beside each, with a click.

SOURCE. INVITATION. LIVING CLAIM.

Dracula watches her write. His face doesn't move.

Serenity looks at the third card. It lies on the flagstone by her foot, plain white, with her own name nowhere on it. Then she puts out her hand, flat, and covers it.

“That one's mine.”

Behind us, through the shut door, the sea knocks again.

CLASS

The Glint

Wing 4: The Glint Hall · Professor Wispwood · 11:00 a.m.

Light, today, in the form of one stubborn lamp. You were asked to make it say something kind. It said 'later'.

THE SKY THAT DAY

Waxing Gibbous · clear

WRITE HERE

What would you leave on the step for something that visits at night?

CHAPTER THE SECOND

In which you learned the name of the bakery cat after work

Then it was Friday and the sky was grey.

Learned the name of the bakery cat after work. It rained again right after. You tried the thing from the Wayfinding class, mapping the street by smell, on the way home.

The mirror said you looked like someone who had been listening to a long story and had just reached the good part.

Bakery, then the laundrette (hot cotton), then the bins behind the chip shop, then nothing for a long stretch, then woodsmoke from somebody's chimney two roads over. You'd never have noticed the woodsmoke if you hadn't been playing. You stood at the corner for a while just breathing it in like a weirdo. You think that's what this whole Book is for, honestly. Making you stand on corners. That came back from twenty-one days ago: The man at the bakery remembered you like the end piece.

The corridor outside the Vault has two ceilings now. The upper one has weather.

Found the lost Tuesday. It was folded into eight in my back cover, with a crumb in it. I've put it back on the calendar. It looks tired.

AN ENCHANTMENT



Mirror, Mirror

6:00 p.m.

The mirror said you looked like someone who had been listening to a long story and had just reached the good part.

THE SKY THAT DAY

Waxing Gibbous · cloud · wind

THE MOON THAT NIGHT



Waxing Gibbous

93% lit · 12 days old · sky cloud

Fattening. Up in the afternoon, if anyone looked.

CHAPTER THE THIRD

In which you oiled the squeaky kitchen door late at night

On Saturday there was a full moon and the sky was clear.

Oiled the squeaky kitchen door late at night. The kitchen smelled of three different days at once and was fond of all of them.

The kettle had been working up to it for years. Tuesday, it said, in a small steam voice, and nothing else. So on Tuesday nothing was done about anything, and it was a very good day.

Shirley said it was typical of you. *Counted the steps to the post box at Amanda's. Nobody else noticed. The river, going gold.*

I've caught a loose moon in my ribbon. It's heavier than it looks, and it hums.

♦ *I'm writing a dragon into the margin. A small one.*

ILLUMINATED



Two-person portrait at the waterfront

A STORY THE BOOK TOLD

What the Kettle Said

The kettle had been working up to it for years. Tuesday, it said, in a small steam voice, and nothing else.

So on Tuesday nothing was done about anything, and it was a very good day.



pressed here, Saturday, October 24

FROM YOUR SCRAPBOOK

Outside, slowly

Outside, slowly

Water and the way through the trees. I wanted both.



JOURNAL

the river, going gold

SOUVENIR

Frost on the car roof in the shape of a map of somewhere that doesn't exist

Outside, slowly · made at 8:00 p.m.

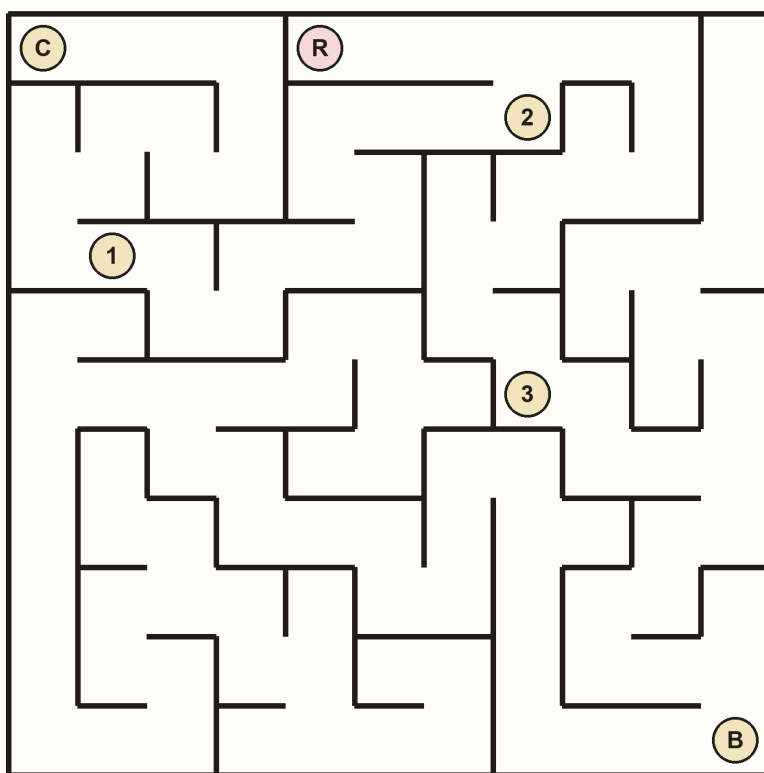
Water and the way through the trees. I wanted both.

MAP THE DOOR HOME

*The wrong castle left a few doors behind. Draw a way from the Count to his open book.
Pass the source, the invitation, and the place where Serenity let the black thread go.
Watch the red chair.*

THE DOOR HOME

Begin at COUNT. Find BOOK. Visit 1, 2, 3 in order.



C COUNT 1 SOURCE 2 INVITATION

3 THE CLAIM RELEASED B OPEN BOOK

R THE RED CHAIR IS A DISTRACTION

I left this side empty on purpose, so your marker can't come through and spoil anything.

CHAPTER THE FOURTH

In which you wore odd socks all day at the library

I remember “amanda” from Saturday’s page. Here it is again.

Sunday came next and the sky was raining.

Wore odd socks all day at the library. Sat with Amanda while she waited for news by the river. The radio was playing something old. Tidied the shelf of things you never use on your lunch break. You didn’t take a photo, on purpose. I kept this from eighteen days ago: You told Amanda about it later.

If one column gets read this week, make it this one. The Academy has company. A composite castle has grown through the East Stacks, which remain shut.

Rooms that belong in other books stand at the windows and look in.

◆ *Tonight I’m holding the pen steady.*

And in your own words:

9:00 a.m.

Wore odd socks all day at the library. I laughed out loud on my own.

CLASS

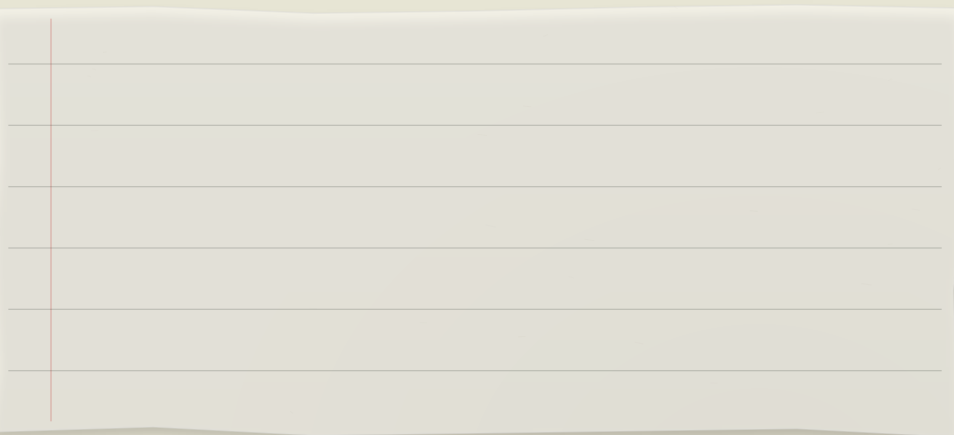
Quiet Hours*The Walled Garden · Professor Momort · 11:00 a.m.*

Ten minutes in the garden with nothing to do. You counted eleven kinds of green and one of grey.

THE SKY THAT DAY

Full Moon · rain

WRITE HERE

A door you went through today. What was on the other side?

CHAPTER THE FIFTH

In which you tried a new route to work on the way home

Then it was Monday and the sky was clear.

Tried a new route to work on the way home. It made you late, which was fine.

A letter came from Penny Blackletter. “I have been meaning to write, which is a thing people say when they mean they have been avoiding the pen.”

The Wrong Castle has put its east wing through the wall of the East Stacks. It apologised in Latin.

The dragon has opinions about the margin. It says it's too narrow. It's right.

A LETTER FROM PENNY BLACKLETTER

A letter from Penny Blackletter

I have been meaning to write, which is a thing people say when they mean they have been avoiding the pen. The truth is simpler: you were in the corridor on Tuesday, looking at the window as if it had said something, and I did not ask what. I regret that. So I am asking now, on paper, where I cannot see your face change.

What did it say?

— Penny Blackletter

ILLUMINATED



Person holding a rabbit

PINNED TO THE DAY

◦ Ink for Today · 9:00 a.m.

THE SKY THAT DAY

Full Moon · clear

THE MOON THAT NIGHT



Full Moon

100% lit · 15 days old · sky clear

Full, or near enough to be argued about.

FROM YOUR SCRAPBOOK

These ones stay

These ones stay

Together by the water. Together with the animals.



SOUVENIR

Sat with Amanda while she waited for news by the river

Nº 42
KEEP THIS
MOMENT

These ones stay · made at 8:00 p.m.

Together by the water. Together with the animals.

CHAPTER THE SIXTH

In which a few small things were kept

On Tuesday there was a full moon.

That you missed writing in here on the two days you didn't.

There's a stair between the supper tables, going up to a hall nobody was invited to. The soup is warm up there.

♦ *I've given the dragon a bigger margin. It's asked for a window, a chair and a dry bit of bench.*

ILLUMINATED



Two-person portrait by the sea at sunset

CHAPTER THE SEVENTH

In which a few small things were kept · Wednesday

And then it was Wednesday. This is the last page I have from that week.

The dragon's asleep on the page. I closed the book gently around it. It's snoring in the Index's ear. The Index is being brave.

You chose to send the Count back by terms. Ambrose steadied the supper table.

The Count read the terms he had signed and stepped towards the threshold. Serenity still held the living claim.

CLUB

**The Compass Society**

7:00 p.m.

The society walked the school's perimeter and wrote down everything that had changed since September. Seventeen things. One was you.

THE SKY THAT DAY

Waning Gibbous

WRITE HERE

Write the shortest ghost story you can. One sentence will do.

Handwriting practice area with a vertical red line and horizontal blue lines.

I don't want this part falling out when I shut.

On Tuesday, you wrote:

"That I missed writing in here on the two days I didn't."

I can close my covers now. This part is kept.

The End

OF THIS WEEK

7 nights braided · 2 scenes read · 225 of your own words



The Tale of Your Week · Issue No. 4 · Every week of October is gathered in October's book · Made with ReEnchanted